next door, kept foul-mouthing the police and the IB. He said he had a licensed pistol, which he had kept loaded.

'If the buggers came, I would have shot them—or myself,' he said.

I spoke less, and mostly listened to the conversations. I was yet to fully understand what the world was calling the ISRO spy case. I gathered all the back files of dailies since my arrest and went through them. The more I read and listened, the more amused I was with the ingenuity of the Malayalam newspapers and the myriad imaginations of its journalists (The English papers, especially those reporters and editors who knew a bit about science and technology, did not buy the spicy tales dished out by the Kerala police and the IB; some even pooh-poohed the sleuths' theories).

One of the first journalists to see through the hollowness of the spy case was J Rajasekharan Nair of *Savvy* magazine. When he came to interview me, he came across as another journalist keen on giving a new spin to the spy case. After spending a few hours interviewing me, Rajasekharan Nair was convinced that the case was cooked up. He wrote a story picking holes in the Kerala Police and IB theories, but his editors found his story, which ran contrary to the popular perception difficult to believe and held it back.

Soon, India Today editor Sekhar Gupta and Asianet journalist T N Gopakumar came out with stories questioning the fundamentals of the case. This left Rajasekharan Nair frustrated as he never got credit for being the first one to puncture the IB bogey as his story, written before the others', gathered dust at the editor's desk.

But, in a land of total literacy where Malayalam papers are the self-appointed evangelists of information and intellectualism, this was the sensational ISRO spy case. Two space scientists sold India's rocket secrets to an enemy country for money and sexual favours. The spy ring with an inspector general of Kerala Police as a facilitator consisted of agents from Maldives, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.

It was an irony that while my foreign friends, mostly scientists, and people like Kanwal Grover ridiculed the spy case as a cruel joke on ISRO and me, people in Kerala swallowed it hook, line and sinker.